



The Sun alters the tides, too.

The Moon's gravitational pull gives the Earth's oceans a bulge. Sea levels change in particular areas as the Earth spins.

The red arrow represents the Earth's rotational spin.

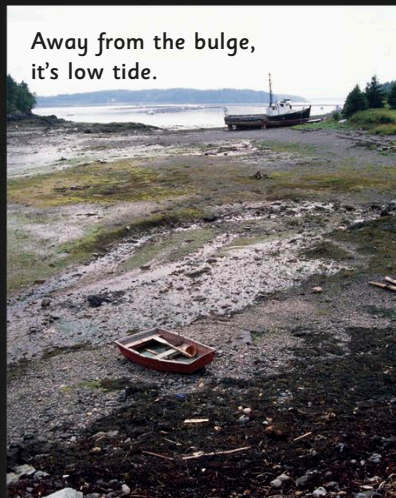
The Moon

... ever seen from the Earth.

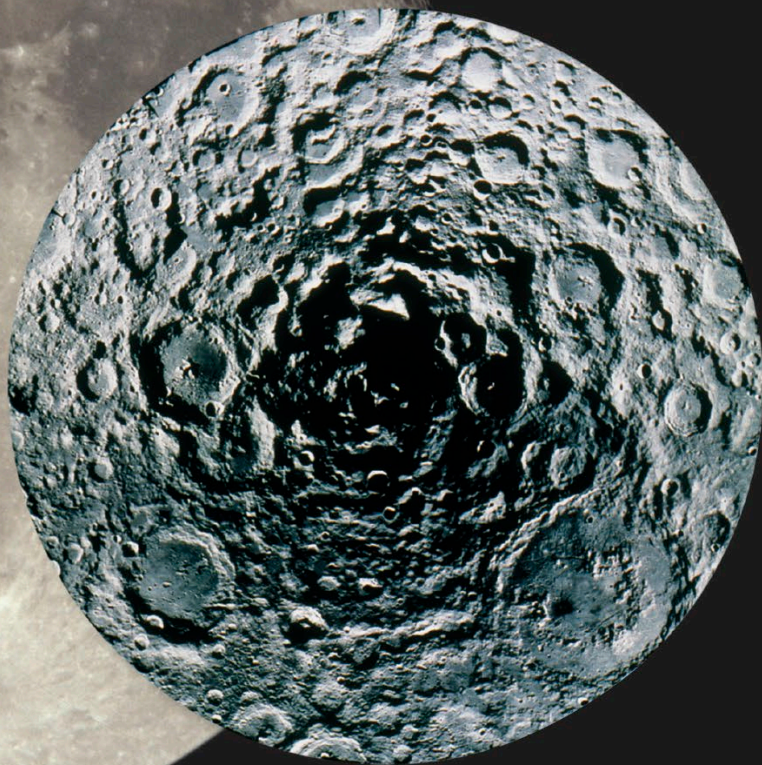
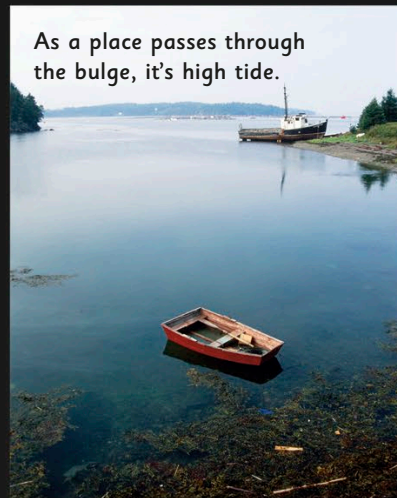
Tide control

The rise and fall of the Earth's oceans twice daily is mainly caused by the Moon's gravitational pull, which makes the ocean bulge a few metres in one direction. This bulge moves very slowly, but appears to sweep round the Earth as it turns.

Away from the bulge, it's low tide.



As a place passes through the bulge, it's high tide.

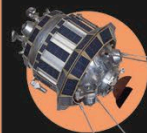


A battered past

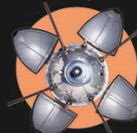
The Moon has been badly battered by asteroids in its long history, leaving its surface full of craters.

Moon missions

Many unmanned space probes have been sent to investigate the Moon, including those below.



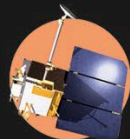
Luna 3, a Soviet probe, took the first pictures of the far side of the Moon in 1959.



Luna 9, a Soviet probe, made the first soft landing on the Moon in 1966.



Lunar Prospector, a US probe, discovered ice near the Moon's poles in 1999.



Lunar Reconnaissance Orbiter, a NASA probe, has been mapping the Moon since 2009.